and renewable energy, while his son, Omar Abdullah, was elected to lead Srinagar's state assembly as its chief minister, bolstering the power of Jammu and Kashmir state's relations with the central government.

Free elections were held in Jammu and Kashmir in 2005 for the first time in years, when violence in the Vale of Kashmir briefly declined as the regularly scheduled Peace Bus started to cross the Line of Control that April between Srinagar and Muzaffarabad. But that spring thaw did not last long, suicide bombings increasing as soon as Kashmiris began to hope for permanent reconciliation among their diverse parties. Every market and crowded theater, any bus terminal or train station, became a target for terrorists, who had nothing better to live for, it seemed, than random acts of violence and killing innocents. How could so many young men find death linked to murder more inviting and appealing than the infinitely wondrous prospects of life itself?

In June 2008, Kashmir erupted again when the Congress-led provincial government transferred ninety-nine acres of empty land to the Amarnath Shrine Board, run by Hindus, to be used for building rest houses and medical stations for the thousands of Hindu pilgrims who annually trekked an arduous twenty-six miles to the icicle cave of Amarnath, where Hindus believe Lord Shiva lives inside the mountain. This *yatra* (pilgrimage trek) often proved fatal to elderly devotees, and the idea of erecting rest houses on the unused land seemed to state leaders both sensible and humane. But protests flared in every quarter of Srinagar as news of the "giveaway" of property to "attract" more Hindu tourists to Kashmir spread, triggering mass outcries of "Azaadi!" Troops shot and killed several of the most militant Muslims, injuring hundreds more, as Kashmir's Hurriyat Conference led marches of up to 100,000 shouting protesters through Srinagar's streets, demanding that Indian troops be withdrawn once and for all from the Vale.

Then the state government changed its mind, taking back the gift of land from the Hindu Shrine Board, triggering protests throughout Jammu against Kashmir's "spineless" administration. Hindutva BJP activists nationwide hoped to benefit in the 2009 elections from what Narendra Modi called the "betrayal of all Hindus" by Kashmir's "cowardly" state government. Hurriyat leader Shahid-ul-Islam urged Kashmiri protesters to remain calm and prove that Kashmiri Muslims were determined to win their freedom peacefully from India's "terrorist" Hindu troops. Another, more militant Hurriyat leader, Sheikh Abdul Aziz, was shot dead by an officer as he cried aloud for "Azaadi!"